

Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
The Songhay Empire c.1450–1591	Situation in Sahelian Africa c.1450; reasons for the rise of the Songhay Empire including military success and use of cavalry, collapse of Mali Empire; key figures e.g. Sonni Ali, capture of Timbuktu 1468; weaknesses of and relationships with client states; political, social, military and economic nature and development of Songhay Empire: Sonni and Askia dynasties; problems and achievements; administration and political centralisation; importance of Timbuktu; centres of learning; role of lawyers and clerics; Shari'a; the economy (including gold, salt, agriculture, trade, slavery, taxation); Islam and traditional religion; territorial expansion; nature and development of the military especially cavalry; <i>jihad</i>; reasons for decline of Songhay Empire particularly succession crises, Civil War of succession and Moroccan Invasion (1591).
The Kingdom of Kongo c.1400–c.1709	Situation in West-Central Africa in c.1400; reasons for rise of Kongo: Diego Cao and Portuguese contact, political and administrative centralisation, population change, trade and commerce, slavery, geographical position, territorial expansion; political, social, military and economic nature and development of the Kingdom of Kongo; the Kilukeni <i>kanda</i> (dynasty); imperial structure and importance of Mbanza Kongo; Nzinga a Nkuwu and conversion to Christianity; religious change and establishment of Kongolese Roman Catholic Church; achievements of individual monarchs; political and administrative centralisation; ecclesiastical structures; territorial expansion; clientage; relationship with Portugal; trade and commerce; slavery; challenges in the 17th century and early 18th century; changing relations with European powers and First, Second and Third Portuguese Wars (1622, 1641–1643, 1646–1649); succession crises and civil war (1665–1709); regional European expansion; relations with client kingdoms, impact and problem of slavery; Beatriz Kimpa Vita and Antonianism.

The Kingdom of Benin c.1500–c.1750	Situation in coastal West Africa c.1500; reasons for rise of Benin: relations and trade with Europeans, role of Oba Ewuare and Oba Ezuola, military factors, geographical location, trading routes and opportunities, introduction of firearms, slavery; the political, social, military and economic nature and development of the Kingdom of Benin; imperial structure and relationship between the Benin City State and the Empire; importance of the <i>Oba</i>, achievements of individual <i>Oba</i>, selection procedures, importance of ceremony and ritual, tribute, the Benin military (structure, tactics, fortifications, key campaigns), material culture and cultural and artistic achievements; religion and the <i>Olokun</i> Cult, commerce and the economy, including trade with Europeans, especially Portugal; slavery; ivory; reasons for the beginnings of the decline of Benin from c.1700: European colonialism, slavery, changing patterns of trade and commerce, succession crises and civil wars, socio-political change.
The Kingdoms and Empires of Oyo and Dahomey 1608–c.1800	Situation in West Africa c.1600; reasons for rise of Oyo and Dahomey Empires and relationship between them: military/ cavalry, infantry/firearms, political change, the importance of individual rulers; political, social, military and economic nature and development of Oyo and Dahomey: role of the <i>Alafin</i>/ King, role of ceremonies and ritual; selection procedures; tax; tribute; imperial structure and relationship between city state and empire; religion and its role in politics and society including the <i>Ogboni</i> and the <i>Oyo-Mesi</i> (councillors) in Oyo; commerce (African and with Europeans); slavery; reasons for the decline of Oyo and Dahomey including: Conquest of Dahomey by Oyo, political divisions and succession crises, military failures and independence movements in client states, economic changes, European influence and impact of Trans-Atlantic slave trade.